

A Very Strong El Niño Could Shake Up Weather Around the World

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Federal forecasters say Earth could be seeing the strongest **El Niño** on record this year. Some people have nicknamed it "Super **El Niño**" or even "Godzilla **El Niño**," NPR reports.

El Niño is a natural climate pattern that happens every two to seven years. It begins when a huge area of water near the equator in the eastern Pacific Ocean warms up. That warm water releases heat into the air, which shifts weather patterns around the planet. Its opposite, called **La Niña**, happens when that water is cooler than usual.

Daniel Vimont, a scientist at the University of Wisconsin-Madison, compares **El Niño** to dropping an enormous rock into a pond. Even places far from where the rock lands still feel the waves.

Forecasters at **NOAA**, the U.S. government's weather and ocean agency, say this year's event fits the "very strong" category. That means ocean water in a key area off South America is more than 2 degrees **Celsius** warmer than average. **El Niños** usually peak in November and December, but this one is already the strongest ever measured for this time of year. Forecasters expect it to last into early 2027.

El Niño years tend to be extra hot worldwide, and experts say temperature records could fall in 2027. **Climate change**, caused mainly by burning fossil fuels, is also warming the planet.

In the United States, southern states often get heavier rain during **El Niño**. That can raise flood risks, but it can also help refill water supplies in the dry Southwest. Northern states tend to be warmer and drier. **El Niño** can also mean fewer hurricanes in the Atlantic Ocean.

Scientists say **El Niño** "loads the dice" for certain kinds of weather, but it does not guarantee what will happen in every place.

Word Treasure

El Niño -- A natural climate pattern caused by warm water in the tropical Pacific.

La Niña -- The opposite pattern, when that Pacific water is cooler than usual.

NOAA -- The U.S. government's weather and ocean agency.

climate change -- Long-term warming of Earth, mainly from burning fossil fuels.

Celsius -- A scale for measuring temperature.

Break it down

Forecasters predict a record-strength El Niño

Explaining El Niño and La Niña

Expert comparison to a rock in a pond

NOAA's very strong category and timing

Global heat and climate change

Effects on U.S. regions and hurricanes

El Niño loads the dice but guarantees nothing

Why it matters

A record El Niño could affect rain, floods, droughts and temperatures in the U.S. and around the world, so understanding it helps people prepare.

Test what you remember

1. What nicknames has this El Niño been given?

- ☐ (A) "Super El Niño" and "Godzilla El Niño"
- ☐ (B) "Desert El Niño"
- ☐ (C) "Tiny El Niño"
- ☐ (D) "Frozen El Niño"

2. What is La Niña?

- ☐ (A) A type of rainstorm in Europe
- ☐ (B) A hurricane name
- ☐ (C) When tropical Pacific water is cooler than usual
- ☐ (D) A NOAA satellite

3. What makes an El Niño "very strong"?

- ☐ (A) It causes ten hurricanes
- ☐ (B) It snows in Florida
- ☐ (C) Water in a key area is more than 2 degrees Celsius warmer than average
- ☐ (D) It lasts exactly one year

4. When do El Niños usually peak?

- ☐ (A) March and April
- ☐ (B) Every few days
- ☐ (C) July only
- ☐ (D) November and December

5. How could El Niño help the dry Southwest?

- ☐ (A) By bringing rain that refills water supplies
- ☐ (B) By making it colder
- ☐ (C) By stopping all storms
- ☐ (D) By moving mountains

6. What can El Niño mean for the Atlantic Ocean?

- ☐ (A) No tides
- ☐ (B) More icebergs
- ☐ (C) Bigger whales
- ☐ (D) Fewer hurricanes

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: C 3: C 4: D 5: A 6: D

1. Daniel Vimont, University of Wisconsin-Madison: Compares El Niño to dropping an enormous rock in a pond whose waves reach far away.